evacuate nearby population centres, their superiors' chief concern was to avoid the spread of alarming news, so they not only forbade evacuation but also cut the phone lines and warned employees in the nuclear facility not to talk about the disaster.

Two days after the meltdown Swedish scientists noticed that radiation levels in Sweden, more than twelve hundred kilometres from Chernobyl, were abnormally high. Only after Western governments and the Western press broke the news did the Soviets acknowledge that anything was amiss. Even then they continued to hide from their own citizens the full magnitude of the catastrophe and hesitated to request advice and assistance from abroad. Millions of people in Ukraine, Belarus, and Russia paid with their health. When the Soviet authorities later investigated the disaster, their priority was to deflect blame rather than understand the causes and prevent future accidents.[111]

In 2019, I went on a tour of Chernobyl. The Ukrainian guide who explained what led to the nuclear accident said something that stuck in my mind. 'Americans grow up with the idea that questions lead to answers,' he said. 'But Soviet citizens grew up with the idea that questions lead to trouble.'

Naturally, leaders of democratic countries also don't relish bad news. But in a distributed democratic network, when official lines of communication are blocked, information flows through alternative channels. For example, if an American official decides against telling the president about an unfolding disaster, that news might nevertheless be published by the *Washington Post*, and if the *Washington Post* too deliberately withholds the information, the *Wall Street Journal* or the *New York Times* will break the story. The business model of independent media – forever chasing the next scoop – all but guarantees publication.

When, on 28 March 1979, there was a severe accident in the Three Mile Island nuclear reactor in Pennsylvania, the news quickly spread without any need for international intervention. The accident began around 4:00 a.m. and was noticed by 6:30 a.m. An emergency was declared in the facility at 6:56, and at 7:02 the accident was reported to the Pennsylvania Emergency Management Agency. During the following hour the governor of Pennsylvania, the lieutenant governor and the civil defence authorities were informed. An official press conference was scheduled for 10:00 a.m. However, a traffic reporter at a local Harrisburg radio station picked up a